



The Honest Sleep Starter

*The five changes that actually matter,
minus the marketing*

A free guide from Clarity Templates
tsjenn.github.io/Sj

Why most sleep advice fails you

Most advice about sleep is a list of twenty tips presented as if they all matter equally. Nobody can follow twenty tips, and the honest truth is that they are not equal: sleep has a handful of big levers and a long tail of things that barely matter.

This short guide is the ranked version. Do only the first thing in it and you will still capture most of the benefit. It makes no miracle promises — biology takes about two weeks to respond, and the first days can feel slightly worse before they feel better. What it offers instead is the honest version of what works, in the order it works.

One rule for reading: if you regularly snore heavily, wake gasping, or have slept badly for months, this is a doctor conversation, not a habits conversation. No guide should pretend otherwise.

1. Anchor your wake-up time

The single most powerful change — and almost nobody does it.

You cannot force yourself to feel sleepy at 10pm. But you *can* choose when you get up, and your body sets tonight's sleepiness partly by when you woke this morning. Pick a wake time you can hold seven days a week and hold it. Within about two weeks, your bedtime starts fixing itself.

The hard part is the weekend. A Saturday lie-in feels like repayment; it works more like jet lag — shifting your wake time three hours has roughly the effect of flying across three time zones and back every week.

2. Use light like the drug it is

Morning light is the signal that sets your internal clock. Ten to twenty minutes outdoors within an hour of waking beats any supplement — even on a grey day, outdoor light is many times brighter than your kitchen. In the evening, run the reverse: dim the main lights an hour before bed and prefer lamps to ceiling lights. The point is less about screens specifically and more about lowering total brightness while you wind down.

3. The 3am playbook

Waking at night is normal. What you do next decides whether it costs you ten minutes or two hours.

- **Don't check the clock.** Knowing the time only gives your mind arithmetic to be anxious about.
- **Give it about twenty minutes.** If sleep hasn't returned, get up. Lying awake teaches your brain that bed is a place for worrying.
- **Keep lights low, do something genuinely boring** — a dull book, a quiet chore. No phone: it's a slot machine for your attention.
- **Return when sleepy, not when guilty.** Sleepiness comes back on its own schedule; your job is simply not to fight in bed.

4. Caffeine & alcohol, honestly

Caffeine lingers far longer than it feels — half of a 2pm coffee is still in you around bedtime. If sleep is fragile, make lunchtime your cutoff. Alcohol is the great impersonator: it sedates you to sleep, then rebounds and fragments the second half of the night. You don't need abstinence lectures — just know the trade you're making.

5. Make the bedroom boring

Cool, dark, quiet — and used for one thing.

A slightly cool room helps because your body needs to drop its core temperature to fall asleep. Darkness is cheap: any eye mask outperforms most gadgets.

Steady background sound (a fan, rain noise) helps when your problem is unpredictable noise, not sound itself. And if you can, keep work, feeds and arguments out of bed — you are training an association, and the training works in both directions.

What barely matters

Expensive pillows and mattresses beyond basic comfort, most supplements, precise sleep-stage numbers from an app, the occasional bad night. Sleep runs on rhythm and pressure, not on merchandise — and one rough night has never broken anyone. Consistency, not perfection, is the whole game.

The one-page cheat sheet

Wake time	Same time every day, weekends included. This is the anchor everything else hangs on.
Morning	10–20 min of outdoor light within an hour of waking.
Afternoon	Last caffeine by lunchtime if sleep is fragile.
Evening	Dim lights an hour before bed. Lamps, not ceiling lights. Alcohol trades a fast start for a broken second half.
In bed	Bed is for sleep. Can't sleep after ~20 min? Get up, low light, boring activity, return when sleepy.
3am wake	No clock. No phone. Twenty patient minutes, then the playbook.
See a doctor if	Heavy snoring, gasping awake, or months of bad sleep despite good habits.

Want the tools?

Everything we make lives at tsjenn.github.io/Sj — including **Rested**, our free honest sleep tracker that runs in your browser, and more guides written in this same no-nonsense voice. The full-length book this guide previews, *The Honest Sleep Book*, is on its way.

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